📘 Pixel Art Prompt Bible: A Comprehensive Style Guide 📘

For Precision, Clarity, and Consistency Across Perspectives

🎯 Purpose

This guide helps creators, prompt writers, and AI-assisted artists generate accurate, reproducible pixel art across all major perspectives: True Top-Down, 45° Top-Down, 60–70° Tilted Top-Down, Isometric, and Oblique. It provides detailed breakdowns of each projection style, form logic, silhouette behavior, lighting considerations, texture rules, and palette guidance. Use it to unify art direction, support prompt-based generation, and refine visual standards.

🧱 I. **CORE PIXEL ART CONCEPTS**

Before diving into perspectives, understanding these foundational elements is key.

🎨 A. **Surface Texture: Smooth vs. Rough**

Describes the pixel-level quality of a surface.

1. Smooth:
    - Characteristics: Clean lines, minimal pixel noise, soft/gradient shading.
    - Techniques: Anti-aliasing (carefully placed intermediate pixels for smooth contours), subtle/patterned dithering.
    - Ideal for: Liquids, glass, polished metal, soft fabrics, rounded objects, skin.
    - Prompt Tags: "smooth surface texture," "polished finish," "soft shading," "clean edges," "anti-aliased curves," "minimal pixel noise."

2. Rough:
    - Characteristics: Jagged outlines, deliberate pixel noise (clustering), abrupt/dithered shading.
    - Techniques: Pixel clustering (grouping similar pixels for texture like stone, bark), heavy/chaotic dithering for grainy/aged effects.
    - Ideal for: Rocks, bark, wood grain, fur, rusted metal, dirt, distressed surfaces.
    - Prompt Tags: "rough texture," "jagged edges," "pixel clustering," "dithered shading," "gritty surface," "chunky detail," "visibly textured."

🧩 B. **Form Complexity: Simple vs. Detailed**

Relates to the number of shapes, elements, and colors used, often tied to sprite/scene scale.

1. **Simple**:
    - Scale: Small sprites (e.g., 8x8, 16x16, 24x24).
    - Characteristics: Strong, clear silhouettes; very limited color palette (2-4 colors); minimal internal detail; iconic/abstract.
    - Ideal for: UI icons, small props, basic tiles.
    - Prompt Tags: "minimalist design," "simple silhouette," "low color palette," "iconic style," "basic form," "[16x16 / 24x24] scale."
2. **Detailed**:
    - Scale: Larger sprites (e.g., 32x32, 48x48, 64x64+) or scenes.
    - Characteristics: Intricate internal details (stitching, trim, cracks); multi-ramp palette (5-8+ shades per base color); complex silhouettes.

    - Ideal for: Main characters, important objects, architecture, environmental set pieces.
    - Prompt Tags: "highly detailed," "complex form," "multi-tone palette," "intricate surface detail," "rich textures," "[32x32 / 64x64] scale."

💡 C. **Lighting and Shading**

Defines light sources and how tones/colors show form and volume.

1. **Light Source Types**:
    - Directional: Specific direction (e.g., "sunlight from top-left"). Strong highlights/shadows.
    - Ambient: Soft, non-directional. Minimal strong shadows/highlights.
    - Point Source: Emanates from a single point (e.g., lamp). Light falls off with distance; shadows fan out.
    - Rim Lighting: Light from behind, creating a bright outline. Good for silhouettes.
    - Prompt Tags (Light Source): "light from above," "directional light from [direction]," "ambient lighting," "point light source," "rim lighting," "casts strong shadows."

2. **Shading Techniques**:
    - Cell Shading / Hard Shading: Distinct, sharp boundaries between tones.
    - Smooth Shading / Gradient Shading: Gradual transitions, creating smooth volume. Can use dithering or color ramps.
    - Dithered Shading: Using pixel patterns (checkerboard, diffusion) for intermediate tones, especially with limited palettes.
    - Flat Shading: No shading; solid blocks of color or simple patterns.
    - Prompt Tags (Shading): "cell shading," "hard shadows," "smooth shading," "gradient shading," "dithered shading," "flat colors, no shading," "uses color ramps for shading."

🧭 II. **PERSPECTIVE TYPES & CHARACTERISTICS**

Choosing the right perspective is foundational. Pixel art perspectives often simplify reality for clarity at low resolutions.

1. **True Top-Down (Orthographic 90°)**
    - Use for: Grid-based tactics, minimalist design, UI tiles, puzzle maps, abstract simulations.
    - Camera Angle: Exactly 90°, pointing straight down the Z-axis.
    - Fundamental Characteristic: Only the top surfaces of objects and terrain are visible. Vertical surfaces are completely flattened or represented by the edge contour of the top plane.
    - Depth Representation: No vertical depth. Objects appear flat. Size differences indicate horizontal scale, not height.
    - Character View: Seen from directly above (e.g., circle for head, simple body form). Readability relies on silhouette and simple internal patterns.
    - Key Traits & Prompt Tuning:
        - Shadows: Omitted or simple, non-directional drop shadows (soft radial or single pixel outline).
        - Buildings/Furniture: Reduced to roof shapes/top surfaces (table is a rectangle, house is its roof outline).
        - Terrain: Flat tiles showing only ground surface. Height changes (cliffs, stairs) are abstract (e.g., different tile types).
        - Modularity: Excellent for seamless, repeating horizontal tile maps.
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    - Prompt Tags:
      "Pixel art, True top-down view."
      "Viewed directly from above, 90 degree orthographic."
      "Only top surface visible, no vertical faces."
      "Flat perspective, no depth cues."
      "Shadows: [omit shadows / soft drop shadow / single pixel shadow line]."
      "Object represented by its top silhouette."
      "Character seen from above."
2. **45° Top-Down (Classic JRPG View)**
    - Use for: Top-down adventure RPGs (classic Zelda), action combat, exploration games.
    - Camera Angle: Approx. 45° between ground plane and viewer.
    - Fundamental Characteristic: Displays both top surface and one forward-facing vertical face. Allows basic height/volume representation.
    - Depth Representation: Vertical depth along one axis (usually 'down' and 'towards screen'). Horizontal depth (away from screen) also represented, often with foreshortening.
    - Character View: Typically 3/4 back view (head, shoulders, body). Allows expressive animation.
    - Key Traits & Prompt Tuning:
        - Shadows: Cast diagonally, adding depth.

    - Buildings/Furniture: Walls show front/side face; roofs visible. Chairs show seat/back. Stairs show steps.
    - Terrain: Ground tiles slightly diamond-shaped/skewed. Cliffs/walls show vertical faces.
    - Foreshortening: Distant elements slightly smaller (stylized).
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- Prompt Tags:
  "Pixel art, 45 degree top-down view."
  "Classic JRPG perspective."
  "Show top surface and one partial front face."
  "Diagonal view, view angle ~45 degrees."
  "Characters in 3/4 back view."
  "Terrain tiles with slight diagonal skew."
  "With [diagonal/directional] shadows."
  "Elements foreshortened with depth."

3. **60–70° Tilted Top-Down (Modern RPG/Sim View)**
   - Use for: Life sims (Stardew Valley), farming games, mobile RPGs.
   - Camera Angle: Steeper than 45° (60°-70°). Closer to True Top-Down but reveals some vertical info.
   - Fundamental Characteristic: Strongly emphasizes top surface, subtle hint of side/front face.
   - Depth Representation: Vertical depth present but minimal. Objects relatively "squat." Ground plane dominates.
   - Character View: Short, somewhat rounded, mostly from above but enough verticality for face/front and short legs.
   - Key Traits & Prompt Tuning:
     - Shadows: Short, cast downwards or slightly diagonally.
     - Buildings/Furniture: Roofs prominent. Walls show thin band or base edge. Furniture tops wide, minimal leg/side details.
     - Terrain: Ground tiles nearly square. Vertical elements (trees, walls) shorter relative to width.
     - Modularity: Excellent for dense layouts where top-down position is primary.
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   - Prompt Tags:
     "Pixel art, 60 degree top-down view."
     "Steep top-down angle, 60-70 degrees."
     "Top surface emphasized, minimal side/front visible."
     "Tilted top-down perspective."
     "Squat verticality, wide tops."
     "Characters viewed mostly from above, slightly foreshortened."
     "Short, downward-cast shadows."
4. **Isometric (30° x 30° Orthographic)**
   - Use for: Tile-based strategy, building games (Factorio), detailed dioramas.
   - Camera Angle: Orthographic, typically 30° from horizontal plane, rotated 30° left/right.

- Fundamental Characteristic: Renders equal proportions along all three axes. Horizontal axes skewed at 30°, creating a diamond grid. Pixel ratio for diagonals often 2 pixels horizontal : 1 pixel vertical (2:1).
- Depth Representation: Depth via parallel lines. No foreshortening (distant objects same size as close ones). Depth implied by position and stacking.
- Character View: Side-view or 3/4 view, upright. Consistent size regardless of depth.
- Key Traits & Prompt Tuning:
    - Shadows: Stylized or cast along isometric grid lines (2:1 slope).
    - Buildings/Furniture: All three visible faces (top, left, right) equally prominent, no distortion. Walls meet at 120° in screen space.
    - Terrain: Diamond-shaped tiles. Height clearly shown by vertical stacking.
    - Modularity: Highly modular for stacking, multi-story structures on a diamond grid.
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- Prompt Tags:
  "Pixel art, Isometric projection."
  "30 degree x 30 degree orthographic view."
  "2:1 pixel ratio for diagonals."
  "Parallel lines for depth, no vanishing point."
  "Objects with equal proportions on all visible faces."
  "On a diamond grid."
  "Characters standing upright, viewed from the side/3-4."
  "Depth implied by stacking."

5. ⚠️ **Oblique (Cavalier/Cabinet Projection)** ⚠️

⚠️ **WARNING: Oblique Projection and AI Generators** ⚠️

AI often struggles with:

- **Maintaining a truly flat, un-skewed front face.**
- **Consistent skew angle for depth lines.**
- **Consistent depth compression (Cabinet vs. Cavalier).**
- **Mixing perspectives (confusing with Isometric).**
  To improve AI chances (be explicit):

- Use for: 2D dungeon crawlers (early Rogue-likes), RPG interiors, puzzle games.
- Camera Angle: Flat front view, depth lines receding at an angle (often 45°) without foreshortening.
- Fundamental Characteristic: Displays a flat, non-distorted front view; receding depth shown along a single, skewed axis with parallel lines.
- Depth Representation: Depth lines extend back at a fixed angle (e.g., 45°). Cabinet projection often compresses depth lines (e.g., half length); Cavalier projection uses full length.
- Character View: Side or 3/4 view, upright on flat ground plane.
- Key Traits & Prompt Tuning:
    - Shadows: Simple shapes extending back along depth angle or just beneath.
    - Buildings/Furniture: Walls often tall, flat rectangles (front view), side walls recede at skewed angle. Furniture shows clear front, skewed sides/back.

    - Terrain: Ground tiles often simple squares/rectangles.
    - Modularity: Can be modular, but depth alignment tricky due to skew/compression.
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- "Flat front face"
  "Vertical lines remain upright"
  "Depth recedes along a single axis"
  "Skewed back at [specific angle, e.g., 45°]"
  "No perspective foreshortening along depth axis"
  Optional (AI may struggle): "Depth is compressed to half length (Cabinet)" OR "Depth is full length (Cavalier)"
  Even with detailed prompts, expect inconsistencies requiring editing.
- Prompt Tags (Use with ⚠️Caution⚠️):
  "Pixel art, Oblique projection."
  "Flat front view, depth skewed back."
  "Vertical lines are straight and upright."
  "Depth recedes at a [45 degree / 30 degree] angle."
  "No foreshortening on the front plane."
  "Depth is represented by parallel lines receding back."
  "[Optional, less reliable for AI] Depth is compressed to half scale (Cabinet projection)."
  "[Optional, less reliable for AI] Depth is at full scale (Cavalier projection)."

🖼️ III. **OBJECT & STRUCTURE EXAMPLES BY PERSPECTIVE**

This table illustrates how common objects and structures transform across perspectives.

Object Type	**True Top-Down (90°)**	**45° Top-Down**	**60–70° Tilted Top-Down**	**Isometric (30°x30°, 2:1 Ratio)**	**⚠️Oblique (e.g., 45° Receding)**
Simple Cube	A single square, representing the top face only.	Top square visible, plus one side face, both slightly skewed.	Top square dominant, very thin sliver of one side face visible.	Top diamond, two side diamond faces, all equally scaled. Edges are 2:1 pixel lines.	Front face is a perfect square. Top and one side face recede at chosen angle (e.g., 45°).

Chair	Circular/square outline for seat. No back/legs.	Angled seat, visible back, front/side legs partially visible receding.	Wide seat top, short back, minimal leg detail.	Top seat face, two side faces of back/legs receding at 30°. Legs vertical on grid.	Flat front view of seat edge & front legs. Seat top, back, and side legs recede at angle.
Tree (Simple)	Circular/blob by canopy outline. No trunk visible.	Angled canopy shape, part of trunk visible beneath, receding diagonally.	Broad canopy dominates. Short, slightly tapered trunk visible directly below.	Canopy as diamond/layered shape. Trunk extends vertically on grid.	Foliage layers flat to viewer. Trunk vertical. Entire tree depth recedes at angle.
Small House Rectangular	Rectangular roof outline. No walls visible.	Roof visible, plus one main wall face (e.g., front or side). Details like door/window visible on that wall.	Roof is very dominant. A thin band of one wall visible below eaves.	Two wall faces and roof visible, all at 30° angles. No foreshortening. Details on both visible walls.	Front wall is a flat, un-distorted rectangle with roof line. Side wall and roof depth recede at chosen angle.
Wall (Corner)	Two perpendicular lines on floor, or just floor tile.	Two wall faces meeting at an angle, tops visible.	Top edge of walls very prominent, short sliver of wall faces.	Two wall sections meet at 120° (screen space), aligned to isometric grid.	One wall flat to viewer. Perpendicular wall recedes at chosen angle.

Cylinder (e.g., Barrel)	Perfect circle (top view).	Elliptical top, visible curved side.	Wide elliptical top, short curved side.	Elliptical top on isometric plane, straight vertical sides.	Front view might be flat rectangle (if side-on) or circle (if top-down front). Sides recede.

🔁 IV. **BUILDING REPRODUCIBLE PROMPTS**

Craft effective prompts by combining detailed parameters:

1. Core Subject & Quantity: What is it? How many? (e.g., "A lone knight," "3 potion bottles").
2. Perspective Type: **CRUCIAL**. (e.g., "True top-down 90°," "Isometric 2:1 ratio").
3. Environment/Setting: Where is it? (e.g., "on a dirt path," "in a dark dungeon corner").
4. Object/Scene Details & Form: Specific features, shape, structure. Link to Form Complexity. (e.g., "worn wooden planks," "simple geometric form").
5. Surface Texture & Material: Pixel-level properties. Link to Smooth vs. Rough. (e.g., "rough stone texture," "smooth metallic surface").
6. Lighting & Shading: Light source(s), shadow behavior. (e.g., "sunlight from top left," "cell shaded").
7. Color Palette/Tone: Mood or specific color constraints. (e.g., "limited palette, 16 colors," "warm earthy tones").
8. Scale & Resolution Hint: Suggests detail level. (e.g., "suitable for a 32x32 sprite," "16-bit era graphics").
9. Style/Mood: Overall aesthetic. (e.g., "fantasy," "sci-fi," "cute," "gritty").
10. Composition/Arrangement (for scenes): Element positioning. (e.g., "chest in foreground," "buildings clustered").
11. Negative Constraints (⚠️Optional for AI⚠️): What NOT to include. (e.g., "no text," "no dithering" This doesn't always work.).

💡 V. **STYLE-SPECIFIC PROMPT EXAMPLES (COMPLEX SCENARIOS)**

These demonstrate applying the principles to more complex scenes. (Your original examples were excellent and are largely retained here, with minor tweaks for consistency if needed).

A. **Complex Oblique Dungeon Corner Prompt:**

⚠️ **WARNING: Oblique Projection (see above)**⚠️

"Pixel art of a dark, grimy dungeon corner.

Perspective: Oblique projection. Front wall facing viewer is flat and undistorted. Depth recedes back into the lower-left at a 45 degree angle. Vertical lines of walls and objects must remain perfectly upright. Depth lines should be parallel. (AI may struggle with consistent skew/depth).

Environment: Walls of rough, detailed stone blocks with cracks and moss. Floor: simple, dark square tile pattern.

Objects: Ornate wooden chest in corner (front face flat, sides recede at 45° oblique angle,

smooth metal banding, detailed front lock). Simple wooden barrel slightly in front of wall (front face flat, side recedes). Lit torch on flat front wall.
Lighting: Point light from torch. Shadows cast downwards and lower-left along oblique depth axis. High contrast.
Texture/Form: Rough textures on stone/wood (pixel clustering, dithering). Detailed form for chest/torch.
Palette: Limited, dark dungeon tones (grays, browns, deep reds/oranges for torch, green for moss).
Scale: Larger scene element, 64x64+ detail level.
Mood: Atmospheric, claustrophobic dungeon."

B. **Complex Isometric Floating Island Prompt:**
"Pixel art of a small floating island.
Perspective: Strict Isometric projection, 30°x30° angles, 2:1 pixel ratio for diagonals. No perspective foreshortening. Parallel depth lines. Objects stack on isometric grid.
Environment: Small, detailed grass patch on island top. Island sides of rough, jagged dirt/stone (vertical depth). Smooth, light blue clouds below.
Objects: Single oak tree (canopy: detailed diamond shape on iso-grid; trunk: vertical). Small brown treasure chest near tree (sits squarely on iso-grid, three faces equal proportion). Winding dirt path on grass (follows iso-diamond grid).
Lighting: Soft, ambient sunlight from above. Gentle shading (smooth color ramps) for volume. Short, simple shadows directly below objects.
Texture/Form: Rough texture for dirt/stone (dithering, clustering). Smooth texture for clouds. Detailed form for tree/island.
Palette: Vibrant fantasy (rich greens, earthy browns, light blues, golds). Multi-tone palette.
Scale: Medium detail, approx. 64x64 to 128x128 complexity.
Mood: Whimsical, high-fantasy, peaceful."

C. **Complex 45° Top-Down Town Square Prompt:**
"Pixel art of a small town square.
Perspective: Classic 45 degree top-down view. Shows top surface and partial front face of buildings/objects. Subtle foreshortening for depth. Characters in 3/4 back view.
Environment: Paved with detailed cobblestone tiles. Edges: segments of vertical stone walls, building bases. Simple wooden fence along one edge (tops of posts, receding horizontal planks visible).
Objects: Central stone fountain (top rim visible, basin shows curving front face, water with smooth flowing blue pixels/highlights). Simple wooden benches (angled seats, receding legs). Scattered small bushes (rounded tops, visible short sides).
Lighting: Directional sunlight from upper-left. Diagonal shadows to lower-right (strong depth/volume). Smooth shading on rounded forms, cell shading on structures.
Texture/Form: Rough texture on cobblestones/stone walls. Smooth texture on water. Detailed fountain, simple benches/bushes.

Palette: Warm, inviting town colors (greys, browns, greens, blues). Multi-tone.
Scale: Medium-to-high detail, e.g., 128x128 area.
Mood: Lively, classic RPG town, inviting."

D. Complex 60-70° Tilted Farmland Scene Prompt:
"Pixel art of a small farmland plot.
Perspective: Steep tilted top-down view (approx. 65°). Top surfaces most prominent. Minimal vertical sides/fronts visible. Emphasize horizontal layout, modularity.
Environment: Tilled dark brown soil tiles in neat rows. Green grass tiles surround. Simple wooden fence borders (top posts very visible, minimal suggestion of vertical posts/planks below).
Objects: Rows of small detailed pixel art crops (e.g., corn stalks, berry bushes - broad leafy tops, minimal stalk/base). Simple scarecrow (head/shoulders visible from above, very short body, barely visible legs). Small water well (top rim wide/clear, thin band for stone side).
Lighting: Soft, ambient light from directly above. Very short, soft shadows directly beneath objects (or omitted for readability). Flat shading or minimal gradient.
Texture/Form: Rough texture for soil/wood. Smooth/simple for grass/crops. Simple, squat forms, wide tops. Highly modular.
Palette: Bright, cheerful farming sim colors (greens, browns, yellows, reds). Limited to medium.
Scale: Highly modular tiles, small sprites (e.g., 32x32 or 48x48 tile elements).
Mood: Cozy, productive, calm, simulation-style."

Thanks for reading - **George Bailey**